



VIA NOVA

SPRING NEWSLETTER

ISAAC LEJEUNE

Via Nova this Spring

Dear Friends,

I wanted to share with you an update my spring semester in Via, and the fruits I have experienced throughout this year. Firstly, I'll speak to how I have been formed this semester, specifically in my spiritual life and in regards to my discernment. Then I would like to update you all on the spring events that have taken place here at Via.

Prayer

These past few months in Via have been extremely nourishing for my spiritual life. As the saints of our tradition attest, a vital component to growing in the spiritual life is consistency. Consistently showing up to prayer and placing your life in the Lord's hands each day is essential to growing closer to Him. There are so many unspeakable graces which come from being with our Lord for one hour each day. I am so thankful for the structured prayer time that Via provides. In the way that a seedling is watered and nourished, and so it grows, although one may not know exactly how or when the growth happened, so it is with prayer, especially in my life. I do not find there to be especially grand moments in prayer, though sometimes that may happen, rather the growth happens slowly and organically. I have experienced a greater deal of peace, a clearer view of reality, and greater intimacy with our Lord and His Church this year. I realize the importance of being close to the Sacraments, and living in the life of the Church. My love for the Mass, the Sacrament of Penance, and my desire to follow our Lord's will has tremendously increased this past year, and it is definitely due to the structured prayer time Via provides.



Praying the Liturgy of the Hours



Picture of St. Patrick's Catholic Church, where we attended Mass regularly

Study

Throughout the spring semester, we focused our study on Greek philosophy, as well as the writings of Virgil. We had the opportunity to read Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics*, as well as Plato's *Apology*, and *Allegory of the Cave*. It was amazing to see the tremendous wisdom that Aristotle and Plato possessed. Even though they were not Christian, they still seemed to be so Christian in their thought. For example, Aristotle's model of a true virtuous friendship is that friends ought to love each other for the other's sake. This is identical to the Christian calling, to love and expect nothing in return. Of the philosophy we read this semester, Plato's *Allegory of the Cave* was the most meaningful piece to me. His allegory describes prisoners who from their birth have been chained up in a cave, never having seen the light outside. All that they believe to be true comes from their dwelling in the cave. They are completely unaware of the light that exists outside which represents what is truly real. The prisoners are living a lie, where they mistake what they believe to be real for what is actually true.

It is a piece which is truly relevant for our times. In a world where relativism reigns supreme, the allegory provides a meaningful reflection on the subjects of truth and deception. The allegory served as a great reflection for me, as I too can be so blind to what is true, and live in the darkness as if I were living in the light. The allegory invites us to reflect on the parts of our lives that remain in the cave, divorced from truth. The story is a precursor to Christ's claim that, "I am the Light of the world", and that to come out of the darkness, and into the light, is to see Christ's face more fully.

We also had the opportunity to read Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics*. It was amazing to see the clear grasp that he had on reality, and the inner workings of the human experience. Most of the data he uses to support his arguments are simply his observations of people's experiences. It makes his arguments, and the principles he draws from them, real and relatable. The most meaningful concept that I drew from his work was his philosophy on friendship, specifically how to build good friendships. One aspect which he proposed to be necessary for building good friendship was living in community. From his experience he claimed that it was communities that produced friendships, and that through the organic workings of a community, for example; relying on others for food, help, etc, friendships would naturally arise. What I love about his philosophy is that it allows friendships to flourish organically, without too much need for structure or intentionality.

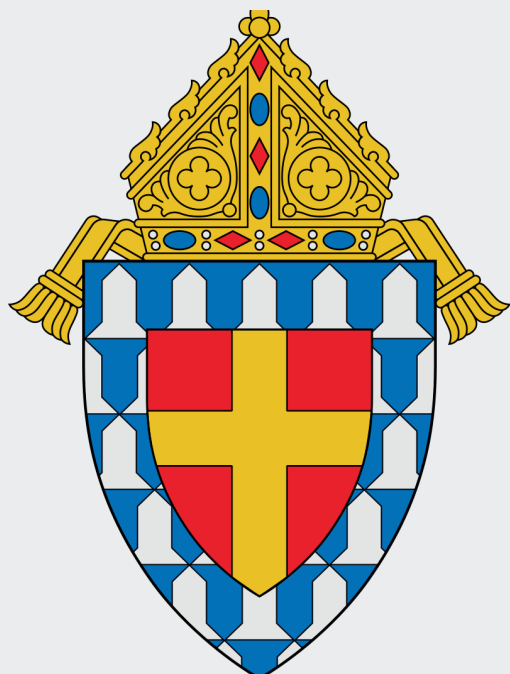


Seminar with Dr. Corey Hayes

We also read Virgil's *Aeneid*, which is a story about the history and founding of Rome. It tells the story of Aeneas, the founder of Rome, and the many trials he endured in order to found the city. Throughout this year at Via I have been particularly fascinated by stories, and in fact I gave one of my presentations on the power of stories, and why they are so important to us as humans. I find it amazing how much a good story can impact me, and how it can shape my view of reality. One of Virgil's famous conventions in the *Aeneid* is epic similes, which is essentially a more detailed version of a normal simile. Virgil was a master of imagery, and through his imaginative storytelling he is able to draw you into the scene of the story itself. One example would be in the battle scenes, where his similes and descriptions of the battle truly help you to imagine what it is like to be there. For someone like myself, who has never experienced war, this story is very important. War has existed all throughout human history, and it is part of the human struggle. Thus to be able to experience it, and to understand how truly horrific the nature of war is, is vital to understanding part of our human history, and what man throughout all of time has experienced. Through his storytelling, I was able to experience this, and I believe it is a testament to how profoundly a story can shape our understanding of reality.

Work

Upon entering Via this past year, my hope was to gain further clarity on the particular work, or occupation, that the Lord desired me to do. I approached this year with a strong conviction that I was called to live the married life, and to raise and support a family. I have a major update in these regards, which is that I have been accepted as a seminarian for the Diocese of Lafayette! Throughout my time in Via I have noticed my heart being drawn closer to the priesthood, and it was particularly around November that I noticed this attraction become most intense. I talked this desire out with our vocation's director, Fr. Dubroc, and since then my love and desire for the priesthood has grown tremendously. For me, this whole experience has been a beautiful example of how the Lord may call us down roads we may have never expected, and that following His voice can make us more joyful than we could ever imagine. I truly am excited for seminary, and the journey that awaits me.



Coat of Arms for the Diocese of Lafayette

St. John Paul II once said, "Life with Christ is a wonderful adventure." That has certainly been the experience of my life, and the calling to the priesthood has been the most adventurous aspect yet. I find it hard to fathom just how extraordinary and beautiful the priesthood is. St. John Vianney, patron of priests, once said, "The priesthood is the love of the heart of Jesus." Jesus Christ comes to us through His priests, and He has established the Holy Priesthood so that He can be with us always, until the end of the age. St. John Vianney also said, "If we had faith, we would see God hidden in the priest like light behind glass." What a beautiful responsibility the priest has, to make Christ present in the world, to be a bridge between God and man. I am so excited to discern my calling to the priesthood further, and I ask that you please keep me in your prayers. I would also like to give a special thank you to Sam Pitre for allowing to work with him this year, and for all that I have learned for these past nine months.

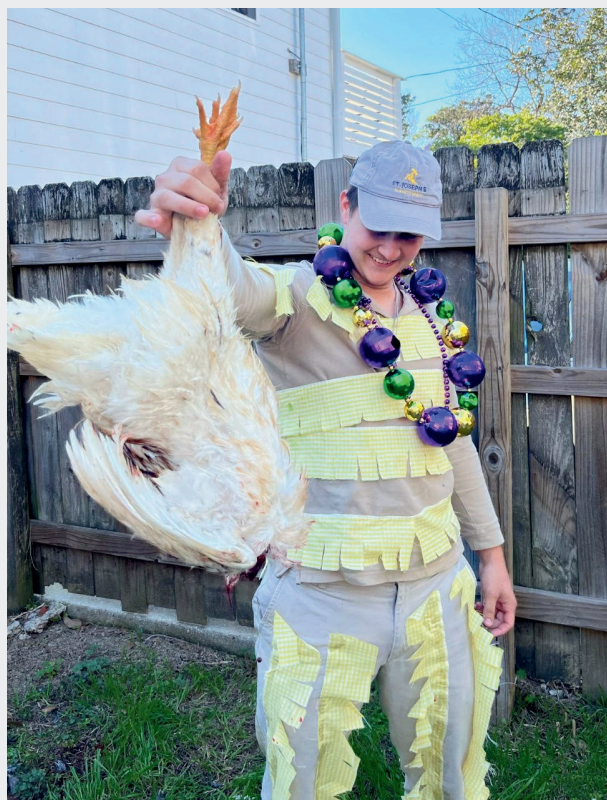
Now I would like to share with you some of the events that took place at the Via house this spring.

Advent Caroling

During Advent, in order to enter into the liturgical season, we hosted a night of Advent caroling at the Via House. It was an exciting night, and we had a lot of people in the community attend. We walked through our neighborhood in Freetown singing Advent hymns at our neighbor's houses. It was surprising to see how receptive our neighbors were to the whole thing. They truly welcomed us, and appreciated what we were doing. After singing for a while we returned to the Via house to eat some gumbo cooked by yours truly. It was a beautiful way of entering into the Advent season and awaiting our Lord's coming.



We were honored to have Dr. Michael Foley speak at the Via House



We put a few of our own chickens in the gumbo pot for Mardi Gras

Lundi Gras

For Lundi Gras the Via house hosted the first traditional Mardi Gras run in Lafayette. It was a great time that really brought the community together. We began the day with Mass, and afterwards we went from door to door begging for ingredients to cook our gumbo, as is the tradition. Those who we met along the way were very responsive to our begging, and were excited that we were trying to revive a bit of our Cajun culture. Between houses, music was played, and we danced in the streets. At about midday we had the traditional chicken chase at Girard Park. We returned to the Via House to eat some gumbo, cooked by Father Jason Vidrine, and we danced to traditional Cajun music on the front yard of the house. Lundi Gras was probably my favorite event of the whole year. I loved that we were bringing back a part of our culture that has largely been lost. Though there are places in Louisiana where you can experience a traditional Mardi Gras, it was special to have it here in Lafayette at the Via House.

Praise on the Porch

This spring we hosted two “Praise on the Porch” events. To describe it briefly, we simply sang songs on the front porch of the house, and invited friends from the neighborhood to join us. We also set up a sort of altar on the porch, composed primarily of icons, statues, and many candles. We sang different songs, some being Lenten hymns, others being praise and worship, and so on. Although we did not gather many people from the neighborhood at either event, one lady did join us for the first session, and she seemed to appreciate it very much. It was a great way to glorify our Lord through song.

Poetry Night

Another event which we host regularly at the Via House are “poetry nights.” At poetry nights we gather as a community to share and discuss different poems that are read throughout the night. This semester we had one of our largest “poetry nights”, where over 50 people attended. The topic of discussion will always vary depending on the kinds of poems that we read.

My favorite discussion this year was centered around the topic of adventure. We discussed what a true adventure is, and why we as human beings seem to crave it so much. The best thing about the discussion was that we talked for nearly three hours and did not even come to a final conclusion. It shows how complex and deep these sorts of questions can be. Poetry acts as a vehicle by which we can enter into the deep and meaningful questions of life. They can be a way to learn more about who we are, and to understand better the world in which we find ourselves. Thus they serve as a great reflection for our lives, and through entering into this reflection with friends, reading poetry can truly be a beautiful experience.



St. Patrick's in New Orleans



Traditional jazz band at Snug Harbor in New Orleans

This year in Via has given me greater clarity on the path that our Lord is calling me to follow. I am confident that if it were not for Via, I would not be applying to the seminary. It is a testament to the ancient model of formation that Via embraces. Nothing of what we do is new or groundbreaking. We simply hold to the time-tested tradition of study, work, and prayer; learning about God, spending time with Him in prayer, and serving Him through our work. Of all three of the pillars, prayer has been the most fruitful for me. The time that we have available to spend in silent prayer is simply indispensable. Through my time spent with our Lord this year, He has revealed to me the next step in my life.

I am so grateful for all of those who have supported me on this journey, particularly my family, support team, and formation team. I want to thank also all of you who have prayed for me this year. Without you my experience of Via would not have been possible. Thank you again for your sacrifice! I am truly excited for the adventure that awaits me in the seminary, and to further discern if Christ is calling me to be His priest. I ask that you please pray for me to our Blessed Mother, that she might lead me closer to the heart of Her Son. If there is any way that I can pray for you, please let me know.

To the heights!

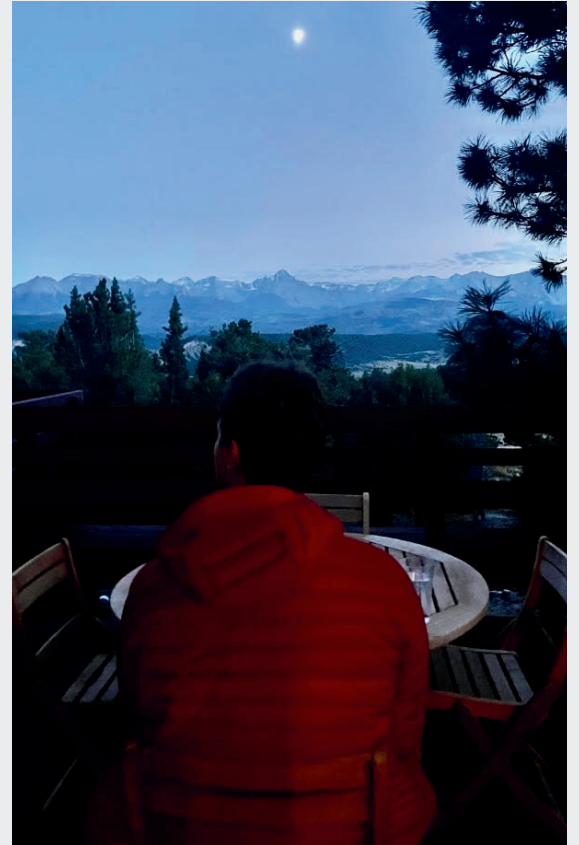
Isaac Lejeune



Praise on the Porch



We celebrated Luke's birthday



View of the mountains of Colorado



Begging at our neighbor's house for Mardi Gras



My patron, Bl. Pier Giorgio Frassati

Prayer Intentions

- That I may cultivate a greater love for our Blessed Mother
- That I may foster a strong community at St. Ben's seminary
- For a stronger conviction of my calling to the priesthood, or whatever vocation God is calling me to
- For all seminarians, priests, religious, and consecrated in the Diocese of Lafayette, as well as Bishop Douglas Deshotel

If there is anything that I can bring to prayer for you, please let me know!
